



Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

After her dominant showing at the Asian Shooting Championships in New Delhi in February, Elavenil Valarivan might have lingered a little longer in the moment. The 26-year-old stamped her class and reaffirmed her status as one of the mainstays of Indian rifle shooting in the marquee 10m air rifle event. She topped qualification with a score of 633.7 and then stormed to victory in the final. The gold medal was her third at the Continental Championships and, on a

personal note, carried added significance as her first international individual medal won in India.

Yet when she stepped out of the finals range at New Delhi's Karni Singh Shooting Range, Elavenil was already looking ahead. "I'm really glad to have won my first international medal at home, but this is also a tournament that's part of my learning experience. Overall, this year is going to be about preparation," she says.

Preparation, she explains, for the major competitions she hopes to peak at later this year. "We have the Asian Games in September and then the World Championships, which is an Olympic qualifying event, in November. Those are really important for us," she says.

Elavenil was not alone in taking that view.

Much of the Indian shooting contingent looked beyond the medal tally at the Asian Championships, instead treating the event as an opportunity to tick boxes, adapt to new International Shooting Sport Federation (ISSF) rules and build confidence in a crucial season.

One reason for this perspective is that India's performance cannot be judged solely by medal count. On the face of it, the host delivered its best-ever showing at the Asian Championships, winning 95 medals: 51 gold, 23 silver and 21 bronze across senior, junior and youth categories. If the count is restricted to Olympic events, including the men's and women's 10m air rifle, 50m three positions, pistol disciplines and mixed team events, India's tally stands at five gold, five silver and six bronze medals.

However, that result came with a caveat. The field at the Asian Championships was significantly depleted. China opted out of the competition, while South Korea did not send its top shooters. Iran, which fields a high-quality pistol team, also did not compete in New Delhi.

In the absence of leading contenders, some shooters qualified for the final with scores that would likely not have made the cut at other major competitions. In the men's

10m air rifle event, for example, the last shooter to qualify did so with 624.6; at last year's World Championships, the qualifying mark was 632.4. India's Arjun Babuta, who went on to win silver, reached the final with 628.0. "I don't even recall the last time I made that score. I think it's partly because we didn't have the top shooters taking part, it was harder to push ourselves," he would later say.

Rule changes

Lower scores in the men's 10m air rifle may have had another explanation. The ISSF introduced several rule changes this year, including reducing the stiffness of the jackets and trousers worn by rifle shooters. This meant athletes had less external support and had to rely more on posture for stability while firing. Although Indian shooters had competed in two selection trials with modified jackets, the Asian Championships marked the first international event under the new regulations.

The 10m rifle shooters were not the only ones adjusting. Pistol shooters had to contend with changes to the permitted shape of their gun grips. There were also format revisions. In the 10m rifle and pistol mixed team events, the top four teams now compete together in the final. Previously, the top two teams contested for the gold, while the third- and fourth-placed teams shot separately for bronze.

A new format also debuted in the 50m three positions final. Shooters now had to complete 20 shots in kneeling and prone, along with sighting shots, within 22 minutes. Earlier, there was designated changeover time between kneeling, prone and standing.

The transition was not always seamless. India's Suruchi Singh and Samrat Rana later admitted they realised only upon stepping onto the finals range that they were not guaranteed a medal, despite topping qualification in the 10m air pistol mixed team event. The pair, heavy favourite, eventually settled for silver.

In the 50m rifle three positions event, Anjum Moudgil, who won